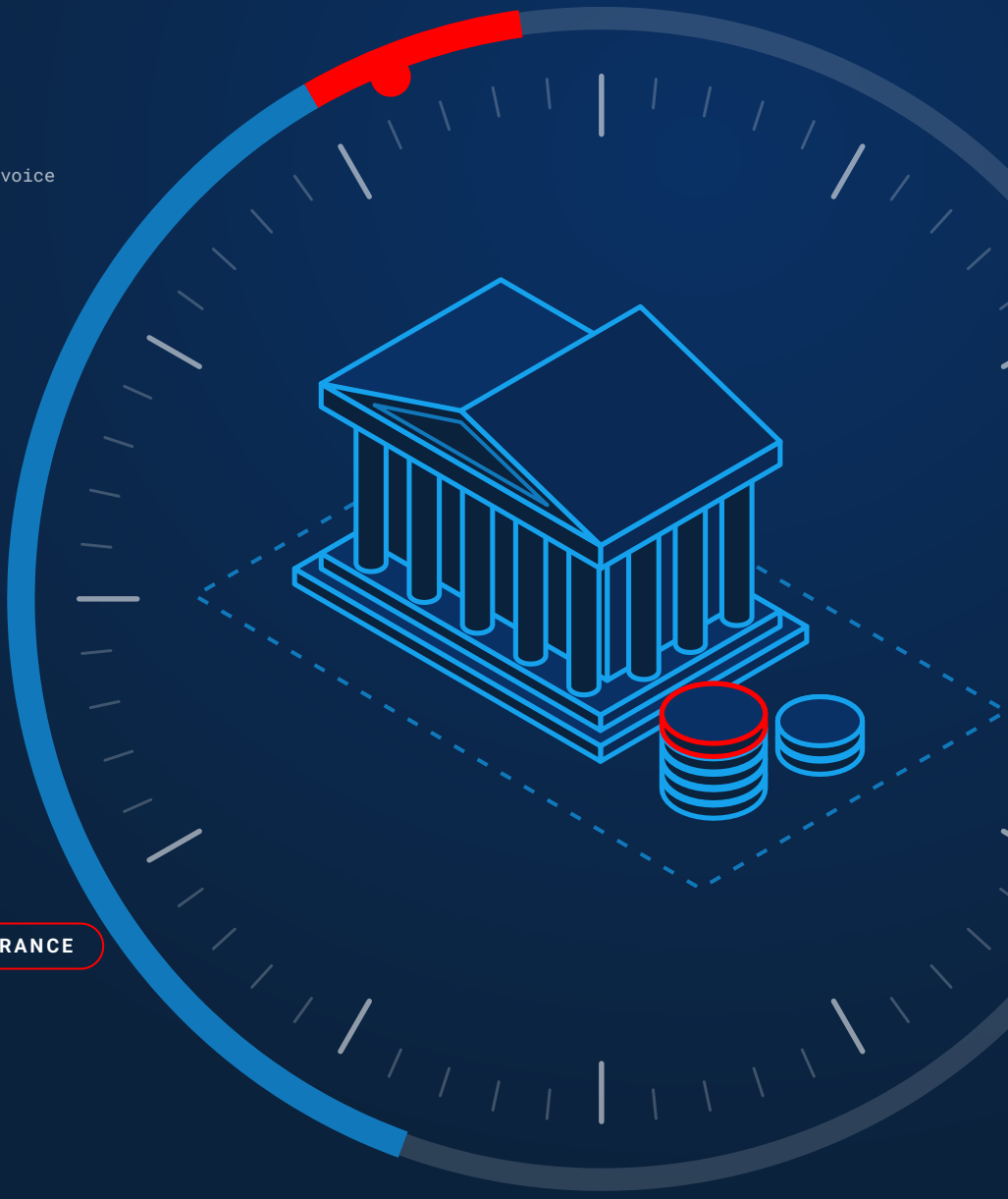
CRISIS PLAYBOOK · NO. 01

WEEK OF 9 NOVEMBER 2026

- T+00:00 Incident declared
- T+00:02 Alert sent · push, SMS, voice
- T+01:30 Escalated · no response
- T+04:10 Team acknowledged



FINANCIAL SERVICES AND INSURANCE

Within tolerance.

A crisis playbook for banks, insurers, payment and investment firms. What to do in the first hour of a severe disruption, how to communicate when email and chat are down, and how to prove you can stay within your impact tolerances.

T+00:00 · T+00:05 · T+00:15 · T+01:00 · T+04:00

INSIDE

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A practical crisis playbook for banks, insurers, payment and investment firms: how to keep important business services within tolerance on the worst day, run the first hour, talk to customers and regulators when normal channels fail, and gather the evidence a board and a supervisor will ask for.

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FOREWORD

Resilience on paper met a real morning on 20 October 2026.

At 06:53 BST on Tuesday 20 October 2026, the utility feed to a data centre hosting europe-west2-b, one of Google Cloud's London zones, failed. A second feed was switched out for repairs, and a control system fault stopped the backup generators from starting. When the batteries ran out at 07:00, servers in the zone lost power. Google's incident report puts the main impact across the London region at six hours and eight minutes.[1]

Customers of Lloyds, HSBC and Revolut reported problems with apps, payments and cash withdrawals that morning.[2,3] The FCA said it was engaging with Google, and the Treasury Committee wrote to the Bank of England and the FCA for details.[2] Google Cloud had been designated a critical third party to the UK financial sector just fourteen weeks earlier.[4]

Since 31 March 2025, UK banks, insurers, payment firms and many investment firms have been expected to show they can remain within impact tolerances for each important business service.[5] This playbook is about the practical side of that duty: the first hour, the messages, the suppliers and the evidence. Our companion intelligence report sets out the regulation and the record in full.

The Crises Control team
Crises Control

INTRODUCTION

Three questions decide how your worst day goes.

Regulators do not expect firms to prevent every disruption. They expect firms to know which services matter most, how much disruption customers and markets can bear, and how they will stay inside that limit when something fails.

Do we know what matters?

Important business services named, impact tolerances set and approved by the board, and every service mapped to the people, systems and suppliers it relies on.

Can we act in minutes?

A severity ladder everyone uses, a first-hour plan with named owners, and a way to reach the response team that does not depend on the systems that have failed.

Can we prove it?

Severe but plausible scenarios tested, communications included, and the timings, decisions and lessons recorded so the self-assessment stands up to challenge.

Resilience is measured on the customer's clock, not the supplier's.

A cloud provider can restore its service on its own timetable. Your impact tolerance keeps running from the moment your customers cannot pay, be paid or claim.

PART 01

Know your limits.

Before a crisis, decide which services matter most and how much disruption is too much.

01 Services, tolerances and a dependency map

02 Severity and escalation on the tolerance clock

03 Who decides: roles and decision rights

KNOW YOUR LIMITS

Important business services and impact tolerances, in plain terms

> **A tolerance is the point at which harm becomes intolerable. Recovery targets should sit well inside it.**

The UK operational resilience rules, set out by the FCA in PS21/3 and by the PRA in SS1/21, ask a firm to look at itself from the outside in. An important business service is one that, if disrupted, could cause intolerable harm to customers or risk to market integrity, or for the PRA threaten the firm's safety and soundness or financial stability.[5,6]

For each one, the firm sets an impact tolerance: the maximum tolerable level of disruption. The PRA requires every tolerance to include a time metric, says it applies at peak times as well as normal ones, and expects firms to stay within it in severe but plausible scenarios, whether or not a third party delivers part of the service.[6]

The deadline mattered. Rules came into force on 31 March 2022, and by 31 March 2025 firms had to have done the mapping and testing to remain within tolerance, and made the investments to operate consistently within it.[5]

In March 2026, reviewing annual self-assessments, the FCA saw progress: clearer methods, annual reviews and some non-time metrics such as transaction volumes. It also found firms not setting distinct tolerances for consumer harm and market integrity, and mapping that focused mainly on technology.[7]

A tolerance is not a recovery time objective. It is the point at which harm becomes intolerable, so recovery targets usually sit well inside it. If your recovery plan only just fits within the tolerance, the plan is the risk.

The practical test is simple. Pick any important business service and ask three people to name its tolerance, its top three dependencies and who declares an incident. If the answers differ, start there.

ILLUSTRATIVE SERVICES

What an important business service looks like

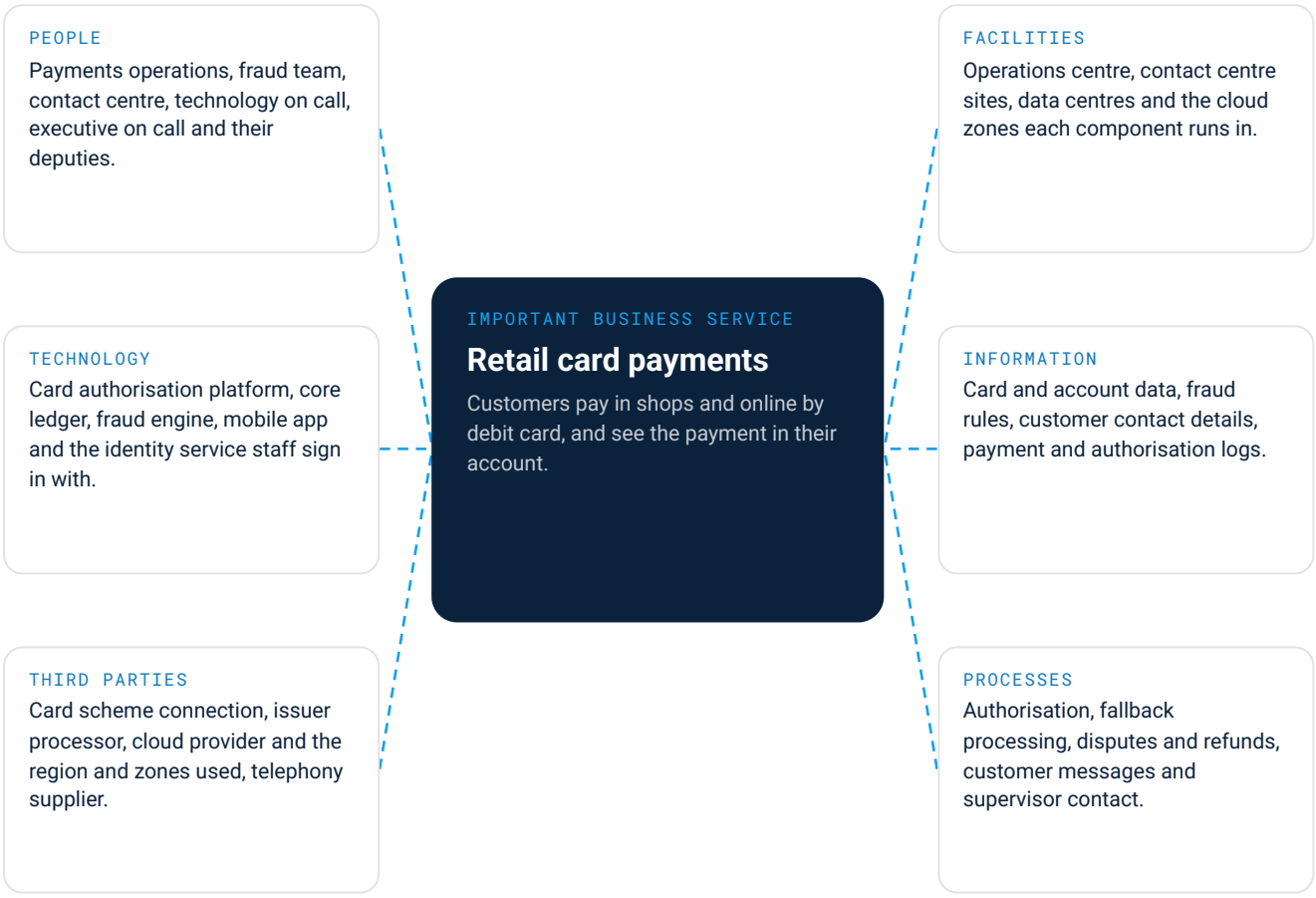
Examples only. Each firm must identify its own services and justify its own tolerances.

FIRM TYPE	EXAMPLE SERVICE	TOLERANCE METRICS TO CONSIDER	HIDDEN DEPENDENCY
Retail bank	Making a payment from a current account	Hours of disruption at peak, number of customers and value of payments affected	Card processor, cloud region, fraud engine
Insurer	Making and paying a motor or home claim	Days to first contact and payment, with extra weight in a storm or flood	Claims platform supplier, contact centre telephony
Payments and e-money	Card authorisation and access to funds	Minutes of failed authorisations, share of transactions declined	Scheme connection, issuer processor, single hosting zone
Investment firm	Placing and settling client orders	Orders missed or delayed in market hours, settlement fails	Order management SaaS, market data, custodian links
Building society	Mortgage completion on the agreed day	Completions missed, with tolerance tightest at month end	Payment scheme access, conveyancer portal

DEPENDENCY MAP

One service, mapped before you need it

An illustrative map for retail card payments: the people, technology, suppliers, sites, information and processes the service relies on, and the limits that apply.



RECOVERY TARGET · ILLUSTRATIVE
2 hours

VOLUME METRIC · ILLUSTRATIVE
5% declined at peak

CUSTOMER METRIC · ILLUSTRATIVE
Urgent cases helped same day

IMPACT TOLERANCE · ILLUSTRATIVE
4 hours at peak

> All values are illustrative. Each firm sets and justifies its own tolerances, approved by its board. The PRA expects every tolerance to include a time metric and to hold at peak times.[6] Recovery targets sit well inside the tolerance.

SEVERITY

A severity ladder for financial services

Agree the triggers in advance so nobody debates the level while customers wait. If in doubt, declare higher and step down.

SEV 1

Critical

TRIGGERS

An important business service is down or badly degraded and its impact tolerance is at risk. Customers cannot pay, be paid, reach cash or make a claim. Data integrity in doubt, or a suspected cyber attack on core systems.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Crisis team, executive on call, regulatory lead and communications lead. Board chair informed.

`Push, SMS, voice call · escalate after 5 minutes`

SEV 2

Major

TRIGGERS

An important business service is degraded but a tested workaround is holding. One channel is down, such as the app but not cards. A material supplier declares an incident.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Incident team, service owners, supplier manager. Communications lead on standby.

`Push and SMS · bridge opened`

SEV 3

Moderate

TRIGGERS

Internal system failure with little or no customer impact. Failover worked as designed. Elevated error rates under investigation.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Technology on call and the service owner.

`Push and email`

SEV 4

Watch

TRIGGERS

Supplier advisory, risky change window, severe weather warning or a peak day such as payday or month end ahead.

WHO IS ALERTED, HOW

Duty manager logs it and briefs the next shift.

`Email and incident log`

ESCALATION

Escalate on the tolerance clock

Severity says how bad it is. Escalation says who must decide next, and it runs on time remaining against tolerance for card payments, not on how the room feels.

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 1 **Service degraded**	Authorisation errors above normal. A workaround is holding and customers can still pay.	Technology on call, card payments service owner.	Incident lead, with the service owner.

↓ ESCALATE IF NO FIX IN 30 MINUTES OR CUSTOMERS CANNOT PAY

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 2 **Tolerance clock running**	Customers cannot pay or be paid. The clock started when the harm began, not when it was declared.	Incident team, communications lead, compliance lead.	Incident lead declares SEV1 and owns the response.

↓ ESCALATE IF FORECAST RECOVERY PASSES HALF THE TOLERANCE

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 3 **Tolerance at risk**	Recovery within tolerance is no longer assured. Failover is untested or has failed.	Executive on call, SMF holder, supplier executive contact.	Executive on call, on options set out by the incident lead.

↓ ESCALATE IF A BREACH IS LIKELY BEFORE RECOVERY

	TRIGGER	WHO IS ALERTED	WHO DECIDES
LEVEL 4 **Breach likely or confirmed**	The service will exceed, or has exceeded, its impact tolerance.	Executive committee, board chair, supervisors through the regulatory lead.	SMF holder and executive committee: remediation, redress and reporting.

Illustrative thresholds for a 4-hour tolerance. Set yours as fractions of each service's tolerance, so the same rule works for a 2-hour and a 2-day service. If in doubt, escalate.

DECISION RIGHTS

Who decides, who acts, who is told

Most delay in a crisis is waiting for someone to decide. Agree decision rights in advance and name a deputy for every accountable role.

ACTIVITY	EXECUTIVE ON CALL	INCIDENT LEAD	IT AND TECHNOLOGY	COMMS	COMPLIANCE	SMF HOLDER
Declare SEV1 and start the tolerance clock	I	A	C	I	I	I
Engage the cloud provider and card processor	·	A	R	·	I	·
Decide failover or manual workaround	I	A	R	I	C	I
Approve the first customer message	I	A	C	R	C	·
Early call to FCA and PRA supervisors	I	C	·	I	R	A
Escalate when tolerance is at risk	A	R	C	I	C	C
Accept a likely breach and set remediation	R	C	C	C	C	A
Media statement and spokesperson	A	C	·	R	C	I
Redress for customers who lost out	A	C	·	C	R	I
Formal incident reports to supervisors	I	C	C	·	R	A
Post-incident review and self-assessment	I	R	C	C	C	A

R Responsible: does the work A Accountable: owns the decision C Consulted I Informed

Illustrative. The executive on call leads the crisis team. The SMF holder is the senior manager responsible for operational resilience in your firm. One A per row, and every A has a named deputy who can act without waiting.

PART 02

The first hour.

What happens in the first sixty minutes decides whether you stay within tolerance.

01 A T+ timeline and where it goes wrong

02 When email and chat are down too

03 Messages, outstanding actions and a decision log

FIRST HOUR

Cloud outage at 07:00

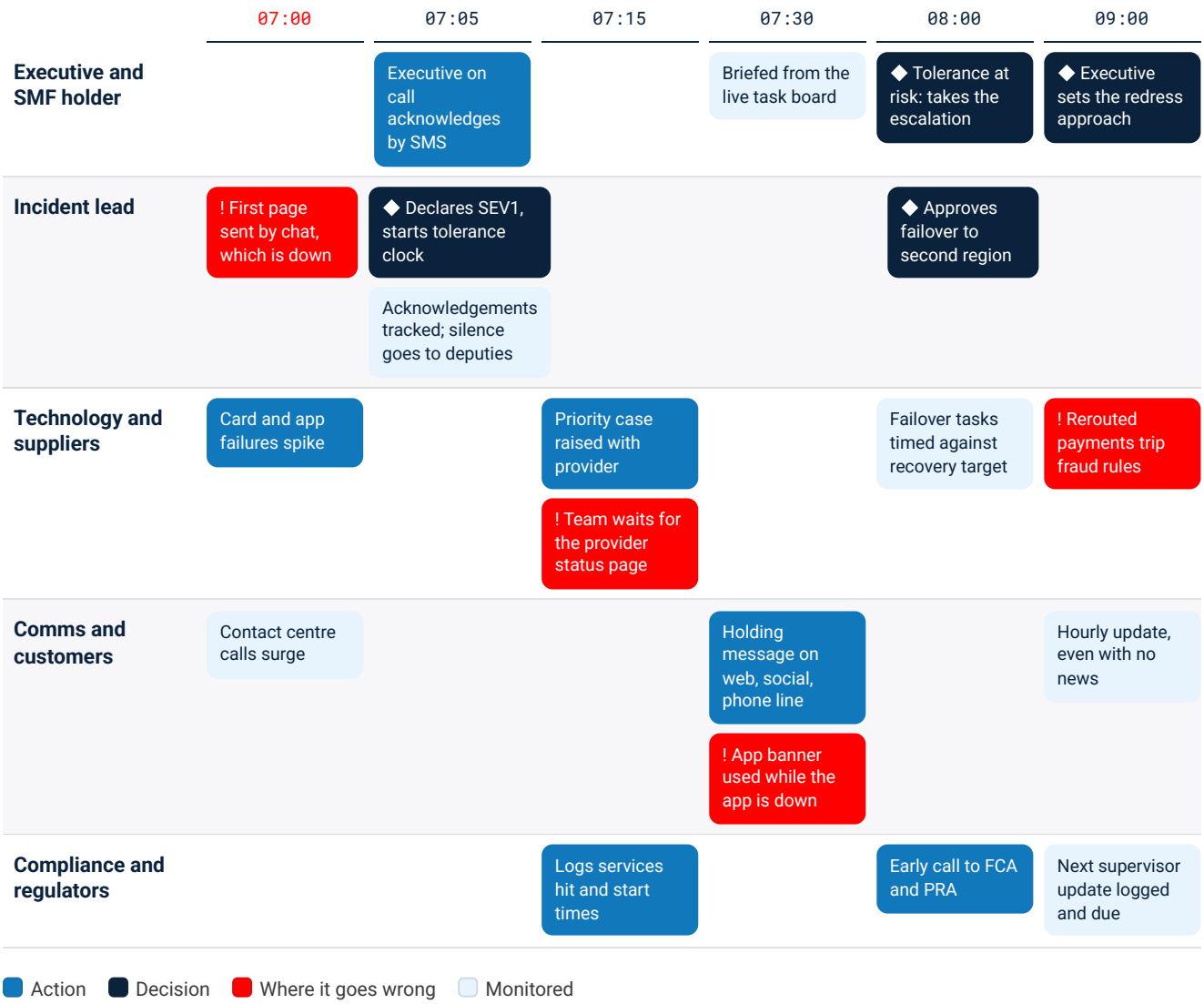
A bank or payment firm whose app and cards depend on one cloud region. Owners are roles.

CLOCK	ACTION	OWNER
T+00:00	**Alarms and complaints arrive together** Monitoring shows failed card authorisations and app logins as the contact centre and social channels light up.	DUTY INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:05	**Declare and page out of band** Declare SEV1 provisionally. Page the team by SMS and voice, not email or chat, which may share the failed dependency.	DUTY INCIDENT MANAGER
T+00:10	**Open the bridge, start the clock** Assign leads and a scribe. Record which important business services are hit, and when.	INCIDENT LEAD
T+00:15	**Call the provider, do not wait for it** Raise a priority case. On 20 October the first public update came about two and a half hours after impact began.[1]	SUPPLIER LEAD
T+00:30	**First word to customers** Holding message on the website, app and social channels. Contact centre script live. Flag customers who need urgent help.	COMMUNICATIONS LEAD
T+00:45	**Decide on failover** Invoke the tested move to another zone or region, or manual workarounds. Protect data integrity above speed.	TECHNOLOGY LEAD
T+01:00	**Tell the supervisor** Early call to FCA and PRA supervisors. Payment firms must report a major incident within 4 hours of detecting it.[8]	REGULATORY LEAD

SWIMLANE

The same morning, lane by lane

Who acts, who decides, where it goes wrong and how progress is watched, from the first failed payment to the second hour.



Illustrative. Each red box is a common failure point: coordination over a channel that shares the outage, waiting on a supplier, the wrong customer channel and an untested route. Plan the alternative before the day.

OUT OF BAND

When email and chat go down with everything else

> **Out-of-band means a route that shares no critical dependency with the systems that have failed.**

The FCA's March 2026 review found firms often had not considered in detail the alternatives or workarounds when their usual communication channels are unavailable, and little evidence that communications strategies are tested in scenario exercises.[7]

In a cloud or identity outage, the tools a firm uses to coordinate may be the first casualties. If email, chat, the intranet and the incident ticketing system all sign in through the same identity provider or sit in the same cloud region, the response team cannot reach each other at the moment they most need to.

Out-of-band means a route that shares no critical dependency with the systems that have failed. In practice that is a combination: an alerting service hosted separately from your estate, SMS and voice to personal and work mobiles, a fixed conference bridge with numbers printed in the plan, and an offline copy of contact lists and runbooks.

Test it the way it would fail. Run an exercise in which email and chat are declared unavailable for the first two hours. Measure how long it takes to reach the full response team, how many acknowledge, and who you could not reach at all.

The same thinking applies to customers. If the app is the channel that is down, the app banner cannot carry the message. Agree in advance which channels carry customer updates when the main one fails: the website status page, social accounts, SMS, branch staff, and the contact centre's recorded message.

Finally, keep the regulator's contact details outside your normal systems. A supervisor's mobile number in a locked mailbox helps nobody.

TEMPLATES

Six messages ready to send

Fill the brackets with confirmed facts only. Agree sign-off rules in advance so messages are not held up.

SMS · RESPONSE TEAM

142 chars

> SEV1 declared 07:05. Cards and app down. Join bridge now: [number] PIN [pin]. Do not use email or Teams. Reply 1 to confirm, 2 if unavailable.

No reply in 5 minutes: call the deputy.

SMS · BRANCH AND CONTACT CENTRE

132 chars

> Cards and app disrupted. Use script v3. Don't speculate on cause. Log customers who need urgent cash or payments. Next brief [time].

APP BANNER AND WEB · CUSTOMERS

> Some customers can't use our app or cards right now. We're working to fix this and will update you here by [time]. Sorry for the disruption.

Say money is safe only once confirmed.

EMAIL · CRITICAL SUPPLIER

> SEV1 affecting [service] since [time]. Within 15 minutes please confirm scope, your reference, a named engineer, an ETA and any workaround.

Copy the contract owner.

EMAIL AND PHONE · FCA AND PRA SUPERVISORS

> Since [time] an operational incident has affected [service]. Likely cause: third-party cloud disruption. Customers affected: about [n]. Tolerance [x] hours, [y] elapsed. Next update [time]. Contact: [name, mobile].

Formal reports follow the rules that apply.

STATEMENT · MEDIA HOLDING LINE

> We're aware some customers are having difficulty using our app and cards. We're working to restore services as quickly as possible and will update our website. We apologise to those affected.

No supplier or cause until confirmed.

CUSTOMERS AND REGULATORS

Telling customers and regulators: what good looks like

Most criticism after an outage is about silence and confusion, not the fault itself.

MOMENT	WHAT OFTEN HAPPENS	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
First 30 minutes	Silence while engineers diagnose the problem.	A holding message on every channel you still control, within 30 minutes.
Supervisors	First call made only once the cause is known.	An early heads-up, then formal reports to the clock. From 18 March 2027 most firms report within 24 hours of determining that a threshold is met.[8]
Vulnerable customers	One generic message for everyone.	Priority help for those who cannot reach cash, pay rent or complete a purchase that day.
Cause	Early speculation, or blaming a supplier.	Say what you know and what customers should do. Name the cause only when confirmed.
Updates	Irregular, and only when there is news.	A fixed cadence, such as every 60 minutes, even when nothing has changed.
Afterwards	Close quietly and move on.	Explain what happened, put right any financial loss and share the lessons.

OUTSTANDING ACTIONS

Services back. The work is not finished.

An illustrative board at 13:30, after recovery. Every open action has one owner, a time and a way to check it is really done.

ACTION	OWNER	DUE	STATUS	HOW IT IS CHECKED
Customer update: services restored	Communications lead	13:30	DONE	Published on web, app, social and phone line
Confirm card authorisations are back to normal	Technology lead	14:00	IN PROGRESS	Success rate against the normal baseline
Update supervisors: recovery confirmed	Regulatory lead	14:30	IN PROGRESS	Entry and reference in the notification log
Call customers flagged as needing urgent help	Contact centre lead	13:00	OVERDUE	Call list ticked off; anyone unreached escalated
Brief board chair and executive committee	Executive on call	16:00	OPEN	Briefing note filed with the incident record
Preserve logs and timeline for the report	Incident lead	17:00	IN PROGRESS	Timeline checked against the decision log
Reconcile failed and duplicate payments	Payments operations	18:00	OPEN	Sample of reconciled accounts signed off
Refund fees and charges caused by the outage	Remediation lead	Day 2	OPEN	Redress log reviewed by compliance
Root cause and fix in writing from the provider	Supplier lead	Day 3	BLOCKED	Awaiting provider report; chased daily

> Review the board at a fixed time, such as every two hours, until every row is done or handed to the post-incident review. An overdue row escalates to the executive on call.

DECISION LOG

Decision log: write it down as you go

Every material decision, in one place, with the time left against tolerance. It is the backbone of the timeline your board and supervisor will ask for.

TIME	DECISION	OPTIONS CONSIDERED	DECIDED BY	TIME LEFT TO TOLERANCE	EVIDENCE OR REFERENCE
07:52	*Fail card authorisation over to the second region*	*Wait for provider fix; manual fallback only*	*Incident lead, advised by technology lead*	*3h 08m*	*Bridge note 4; task 14*

Illustrative example row, against a 4-hour tolerance. Record decisions not to act as well as decisions to act. The scribe keeps the log; the decision owner confirms each entry.

PART 03

Prove it.

Map what you depend on, test the severe days and keep the evidence a board can rely on.

01 Where concentration hides

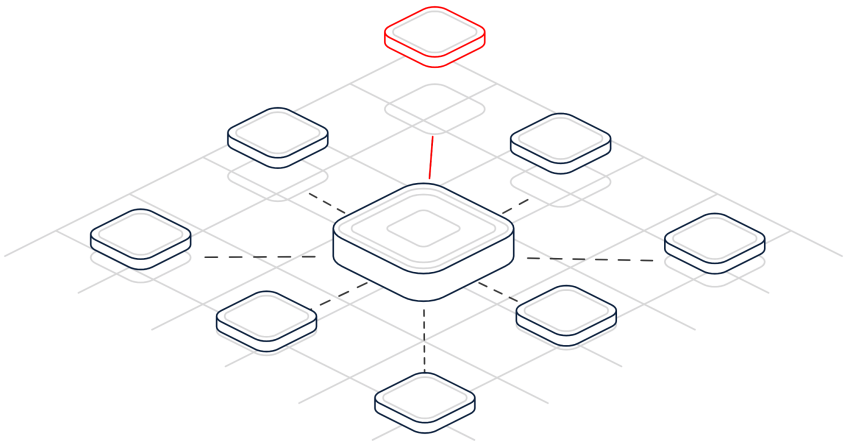
02 Three scenarios and a tabletop exercise

03 Post-incident review and your 90-day plan

CONCENTRATION

Four places concentration hides

The UK designated four cloud providers as critical third parties in July 2026. Regulated firms remain responsible for managing their own third-party arrangements.[4,9]



01 One region, one zone

Services described as resilient may still run in a single zone, or rely on regional control systems that a zone failure can disrupt.

02 Shared tooling

Email, chat, identity and incident tooling often sit with the same provider as production. One outage removes both the service and the means to coordinate.

03 Your suppliers' suppliers

A claims platform or core banking SaaS may run in the same cloud region you chose to avoid.

04 Payments chains and people

Processors, scheme connections and fraud engines need tested alternatives. So do key teams working from a single site.

SCENARIOS

Three severe days to rehearse

RETAIL BANK

A cloud zone fails at 07:00 on payday

THE DISRUPTION

App, card payments and online transfers degrade across the region, not just the failed zone.

WHO DECIDES

The incident lead declares and approves failover. The executive on call owns escalation as tolerance nears.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Corporate email and chat run in the same region, so the first page never arrives.

MONITOR AND TEST

One live board of acknowledgements, tasks and time left. Rehearse failover to another region without email and chat.

PAYMENTS AND E-MONEY FIRM

Card processor outage on Black Friday

THE DISRUPTION

Authorisations fail for 40 minutes at peak, leaving customers stuck at tills.

WHO DECIDES

The incident lead switches route and reports within 4 hours. The head of fraud owns rule changes.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Traffic moves to the standby route and fraud rules block legitimate payments.

MONITOR AND TEST

Success rate by route every five minutes. Prove the standby route carries peak volume, not a test transaction.

GENERAL INSURER

Claims supplier hit by ransomware during a storm

THE DISRUPTION

The claims platform is offline as storm claims peak. Brokers and the supervisor need telling early.

WHO DECIDES

The claims director invokes manual intake. Compliance leads on any data breach, which brings separate duties.

WHERE IT GOES WRONG

Claims taken by hand go missing, and vulnerable customers wait in the same queue.

MONITOR AND TEST

Manual claims logged centrally and reconciled daily. Rehearse a week of claims by hand and count what breaks.

TESTING AND EVIDENCE

Test the severe days, then write it down

What the FCA's review of 2025 self-assessments rewards, turned into six steps.

01 Choose scenarios that could break you

Vary the nature, severity and duration. The FCA questions self-assessments that claim no scenario could defeat the firm without severe testing to show it.[7]

02 Include communications in every test

Declare email and chat unavailable. Time how long it takes to reach the team, the customer channels and the supervisor.

03 Run the tolerance clock

Record the start, each decision and the point of recovery against the tolerance for every affected service.

04 Plan for a breach

Where a scenario would breach a tolerance, document the longer-term remediation plan, with owners and dates.[7]

05 Make the self-assessment decision-ready

Add confidence ratings, second and third line input, and a clear ask of the board, which must review and approve it.[6,7]

06 Learn from real incidents

Use 20 October as a case study. Map which of your services would have been hit, and how you would have known.

TABLETOP EXERCISE

Region down on payday: a three-hour tabletop

A ready-to-run exercise built on the scenario in this playbook. Run it with the people who would really be called, and keep email and chat out of the room.

DURATION	PARTICIPANTS	OBJECTIVE	FACILITATOR
Three hours, including a 30-minute debrief	Executive on call, SMF holder, incident, IT, comms, compliance, supplier leads	Keep card payments within tolerance without email or chat	Head of resilience, with an independent observer

07:00	INJECT 1 Card authorisations and app logins fail. Email and chat are declared unavailable for two hours.	DISCUSS How do we reach the team? Who declares, and when did the tolerance clock start?
07:20	INJECT 2 The provider status page still shows no incident. Contact centre waits pass 30 minutes.	DISCUSS What do customers hear now, on which channels, and who approves it?
07:50	INJECT 3 Failover to the second region is ready, but has never been run at peak volume.	DISCUSS Who decides? What is the risk to data integrity, and who is told?
08:30	INJECT 4 Rerouted payments start failing fraud checks. A journalist asks if customer data is affected.	DISCUSS Who can change fraud rules? What can we say, and what must we not say?
09:30	INJECT 5 Forecast recovery for card payments now runs past the impact tolerance.	DISCUSS Who escalates to the executive and the SMF holder? What does the supervisor hear, and when?
11:00	INJECT 6 Services are back. Many customers missed payments or were charged twice.	DISCUSS How do we find them, put it right and record it for the review?

> Measure four things: time to reach the full team, time to the first customer message, time to the supervisor call, and decisions logged with an owner. Put the results and the gaps into the self-assessment.

POST-INCIDENT REVIEW

Post-incident review template

Hold it soon, ideally within two weeks, while memories and logs are fresh. Blame-free, evidence-led and measured against the tolerance.

INCIDENT _____ DATE _____ SEVERITY _____ REVIEW LEAD _____

01 The tolerance timeline

When did harm start for customers, and when was it detected, declared and recovered? How close did each service come to its tolerance?

02 Detection and declaration

What told us first: monitoring, customers or the supplier? How long from first signal to declaration?

03 Decisions and decision rights

Which decisions were made, by whom, on what information? Did any wait for someone with authority?

04 Reaching people

How long to reach the response team out of band? Who could not be reached, and why?

05 Customers and vulnerability

What were customers told, when and where? Who needed urgent help, and did they get it?

06 Third parties

When did suppliers tell us, and what did they give us? Did a supplier's own supplier play a part?

07 Regulatory reporting

Which notifications were made, to whom, and were the clocks met? What follow-up is due?

08 Actions and self-assessment

What changes, who owns it and by when? What does this mean for our tolerances and self-assessment?

YOUR PLAN

This week, this month, this quarter

Owners are suggestions. Adjust them to your structure.

WHEN	ACTIONS	OWNER
This week	Check that the response team can be reached without corporate email or chat. Print the bridge number and supervisor contacts into the plan.	Head of resilience
This week	List every important business service that depends on a single cloud region or zone, including through suppliers.	CIO or CTO
This month	Agree the severity ladder and first-hour roles. Load the six message templates and their sign-off rules.	Head of resilience, communications lead
This month	Ask material suppliers how they notify you, how fast, and where their own dependencies sit.	Third-party risk lead
This quarter	Run a severe scenario with communications channels unavailable. Time it against tolerance and record the evidence.	Head of resilience
This quarter	Map incident reporting to the FCA and PRA rules that apply from 18 March 2027, and to DORA for EU entities.	Chief risk officer, compliance

FOR LEADERS

Questions for your executive committee

Ask them out loud. Vague answers are the finding.

READINESS

- ? If our cloud region failed at 07:00 tomorrow, which important business services would breach tolerance first?
- ? Could we reach the whole response team in ten minutes without email or chat?
- ? Who is authorised to send the first customer message, and how fast?

EVIDENCE

- ? Which scenario in our last test came closest to breaching a tolerance, and what are we doing about it?
- ? Did our last test include communications, suppliers and the supervisor call?
- ? Would our self-assessment convince a sceptical board member?

CHECKLIST

Are you ready to stay within tolerance?

Tick what is true today. Anything blank is your next action.

- [ ] **Important business services and tolerances approved by the board**
  Reviewed in the last twelve months or after material change.

- [ ] **Every service mapped to people, systems and suppliers**
  Including the cloud region and zone, and key fourth parties.

- [ ] **Severity ladder agreed and out-of-band alerting tested**
  The team reachable without corporate email, chat or single sign-on.

- [ ] **Message templates loaded**
  For customers, staff, supervisors, suppliers and the media, with sign-off rules.

- [ ] **Regulatory reporting clocks known**
  Current rules, PSP four-hour reports, the 2027 regime and DORA where relevant.

- [ ] **Severe scenario tested this year**
  With communications included and timings recorded against tolerance.

- [ ] **Self-assessment evidence ready**
  Confidence ratings, remediation owners and second line challenge.

NOTIFICATION LOG

Supervisor, supplier and scheme notification log

One line for every notification made or received during the incident, so nobody has to rebuild who was told what from inboxes afterwards.

TIME	TO OR FROM	CHANNEL	WHAT WAS SAID	REFERENCE	NEXT UPDATE DUE	BY
08:00	*FCA and PRA supervisors*	*Phone, then email*	*Card payments disrupted since 07:00; about [n] customers; cause under investigation*	*Call note 3*	*09:00*	*Regulatory lead*

Illustrative example row. Formal reports follow the rules that apply to your firm: payment firms report a major incident within 4 hours of detecting it, and from 18 March 2027 most firms report within 24 hours of determining that a threshold is met.[8] EU entities also follow DORA.

GLOSSARY

Words worth knowing

Important business service
A service provided to an external user which, if disrupted, could cause intolerable harm or risk to the firm or the wider system.

Impact tolerance
The maximum tolerable level of disruption to an important business service, always including a time metric.

Mapping
Identifying the people, processes, technology, facilities and information that support each important business service.

Severe but plausible scenario
A demanding but realistic disruption used to test whether a firm can stay within tolerance.

Self-assessment
The written record of a firm's compliance with the resilience rules, reviewed and approved by the board.

Critical third party
A provider designated by HM Treasury whose services, if disrupted, could threaten UK financial stability or confidence.

Availability zone
An isolated location within a cloud region, with its own power and networking.

Out-of-band
A communication route that does not rely on the systems affected by the incident.

DORA
The EU Digital Operational Resilience Act, applying to EU financial entities from 17 January 2025.

Material third party arrangement
A supplier arrangement whose disruption could seriously affect a firm, which must be notified and registered under the 2027 regime.

WHY COORDINATION, NOT JUST NOTIFICATION

Most organisations can send alerts. Few can manage incidents end-to-end.

When a cloud region fails at 07:00, sending the alert is the easy part. Staying within impact tolerance depends on who acknowledged, which workarounds started, what customers and supervisors were told, and whether you can prove it all afterwards.

WHERE INCIDENTS GO WRONG

01	**Fragmented information**	Different teams work from different information.
02	**Delayed decision making**	Leadership lacks visibility, so decisions wait.
03	**Uncoordinated response**	Several teams work independently on the same problem.
04	**Lack of visibility**	Critical actions become difficult to track.
05	**Lack of accountability**	Actions and decisions are poorly documented.

THE WHOLE INCIDENT, IN ONE PLATFORM



Crises Control is an **Operational Incident Coordination Platform**. It helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform.

THE PLATFORM

One connected platform, from first alert to final report.

Crises Control helps organisations maintain operational control during incidents by combining alerting, coordination, execution, visibility and accountability in one platform. Each module does one job; the value comes from how they work together across the incident.

01

ESCALATE

SOS

Frontline staff report an incident in one touch from a mobile device.

02

START

Ping

Alerting and activation: reach people and collect acknowledgements and responses.

03

COORDINATE

Incident Manager

Activate the incident, assign roles, control communication and keep the timeline.

04

EXECUTE

Task Manager

Assign actions, track completion and escalate what stalls, with clear accountability.

05

OPERATE

Control Centre

Real-time view of incidents, timelines, task status and assets.

06

PROVE

Audit & Reporting

Incident records, response analysis and task accountability, ready to report.

07

ASSIST

CRAiG

AI assistant that helps users find information and work through the incident.

THE OUTCOMES

Alerting and activation

Reach the right people immediately.

Operational coordination

Structure communication and response activities.

Execution and visibility

Track tasks, responsibilities and progress.

Proof and accountability

Create a complete, defensible operational record.

Most organisations start with the capability they need today, often alerting, and expand as their requirements mature. Highlighted modules are the ones this playbook draws on.

HOW THE MODULES WORK TOGETHER

How the modules work together in a financial services incident

The cloud outage in this playbook, one module at a time, in the order the incident runs. Crises Control supports your plan; it does not replace it.

01	ESCALATE **SOS**	A branch colleague reports customers cannot pay by card, with their location, in one touch.
02	START **Ping**	The incident team, executive on call and SMF holder are reached by SMS, voice and push; silence escalates to deputies.
03	COORDINATE **Incident Manager**	Card payments is declared against its impact tolerance, with roles, the bridge and the decision log in one workspace.
04	EXECUTE **Task Manager**	Failover, workarounds, customer messages and the supervisor call run as owned tasks with deadlines and escalation.
05	OPERATE **Control Centre**	The executive sees tasks, acknowledgements and time left against tolerance without asking for a briefing.
06	PROVE **Audit & Reporting**	A timestamped record of decisions and messages supports the incident report, the review and the self-assessment.
07	ASSIST **CRAiG**	CRAiG helps the incident lead find who has not responded and which tasks are still outstanding.

COORDINATION
Everyone works from the same incident, roles and log.

VISIBILITY
Leaders see progress without chasing for updates.

EXECUTION
Every action has an owner, a deadline and an escalation.

ACCOUNTABILITY
The record of what happened builds itself as you go.

READINESS ASSESSMENT

How ready is your response?

Score each area from 0 (not in place) to 3 (fully in place) for your financial services organisation, then add up the total.

AREA	THE QUESTION	SCORE 0 TO 3
01 · ACTIVATION **Alert**	Can you reach the right people on more than one channel within minutes, day or night? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Incident team, executives and key suppliers reached by push, SMS and voice when email is down.	0 1 2 3
02 · ACTIVATION **Acknowledge**	Do you know who has seen the alert, and does silence trigger escalation automatically? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Acknowledgement tracked against each important business service; no response escalates in minutes.	0 1 2 3
03 · COORDINATION **Escalate**	Are escalation paths set by role and time, not by whoever remembers who to call? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Escalation tied to impact tolerance thresholds, not to individual memory.	0 1 2 3
04 · COORDINATION **Coordinate**	Is there one shared workspace and log for the incident, not scattered calls, chats and inboxes? GOOD LOOKS LIKE One incident log shared by IT, operations, communications and compliance.	0 1 2 3
05 · EXECUTION **Execute**	Are your procedures turned into owned tasks with deadlines that someone can track? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Workaround and recovery steps for each important business service run as owned tasks.	0 1 2 3
06 · EXECUTION **See**	Can leaders see tasks, people, locations and blockers live, without having to ask? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A live view of services, tasks and teams that the executive can read without a briefing.	0 1 2 3
07 · ASSURANCE **Prove**	Could you produce a timestamped timeline for a regulator, insurer or inquiry within a day? GOOD LOOKS LIKE A timeline that supports self-assessment and regulator questions, produced on request.	0 1 2 3
08 · ASSURANCE **Rehearse**	Do you exercise the whole response, not just the call tree, at least once a year? GOOD LOOKS LIKE Severe but plausible scenarios rehearsed end to end, including the loss of usual channels.	0 1 2 3

0 to 8
Alerting only
You can send messages. The response still depends on people and luck.

9 to 16
Coordinating in parts
Some steps work. Gaps appear at night, at scale or when systems fail.

17 to 24
Coordinated and provable
You can run the response and show exactly what happened.

BUYER'S GUIDE

Eight questions to ask any incident platform supplier

Many tools can send an alert. These questions separate a notification tool from a platform that coordinates the whole response.

01 **Does it stop at the message?**
Ask what the platform does after the alert is sent: tasks, log, escalation, recovery.

02 **Can it prove who acknowledged?**
Delivery is not acknowledgement. Ask how silence is detected and escalated.

03 **Does it run your procedures?**
Ask whether your plans become owned tasks with deadlines, or stay as documents.

04 **Is there one shared picture?**
Ask what leaders see live, and whether it needs someone to update a spreadsheet.

05 **Does it work when your systems do not?**
Ask how teams coordinate if email, chat or your network is down.

06 **Can frontline staff raise the alarm?**
Ask how a colleague on site escalates, with their location, in one action.

07 **What evidence does it leave behind?**
Ask for a sample timeline of the kind a regulator, insurer or inquiry would want.

08 **Can you rehearse in it?**
Ask whether you can run exercises on the same platform you would use for real.

SOURCES

Sources and notes

Sources were accessed in November 2026. Scenarios, templates and timings in this playbook are illustrative and should be adapted to your firm.

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BOOK YOUR FINANCIAL SERVICES AND INSURANCE PLATFORM DEMONSTRATION

Watch a payments outage run end to end.

A live, 30-minute demonstration built around a financial services and insurance incident. You will see one incident move through the whole platform, not a tour of features, and you can bring your own scenario.

WHAT YOU WILL SEE

01	SOS	A branch colleague reports customers cannot pay by card.
02	PING	The incident team and executives are alerted; acknowledgements come back by role.
03	INCIDENT MANAGER	Card payments is declared against its impact tolerance; roles and the bridge are set.
04	TASK MANAGER	Workarounds, customer messages and the supervisor notification become owned tasks.
05	CONTROL CENTRE	The executive watches services, tasks and time remaining against tolerance.
06	AUDIT & REPORTING	The timeline for the self-assessment and the regulator is produced.
07	CRAIG	CRAiG helps the incident lead find information and work through the platform as the incident runs.

Book your demonstration →

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SCAN TO BOOK

COMPANION REPORT Resilience, regulated